

Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

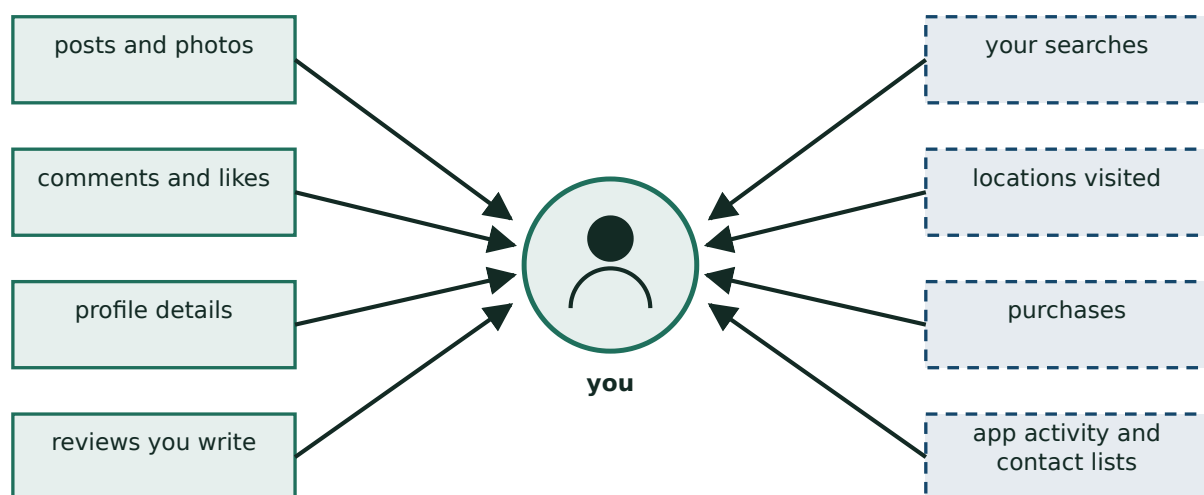
Topic 4.2 - Your digital footprint

A real classroom situation

A B.Ed trainee applies for a teaching post and is shortlisted. Before the interview, a panel member searches her name. The results: her poetry blog, a fundraising appeal she signed, and - from six years ago - a public comment in which she mocks her own college teachers in crude language. Nothing she wrote was illegal. All of it is her digital footprint: the trail of data a person leaves behind online, and which other people can find. The panel did not ask about the comment. They simply formed an impression. This topic is about making that impression a true one.

How a digital footprint grows

Solid boxes: your active footprint. Dashed boxes: the passive part you never chose.



The passive part is collected, merged and profiled - and you see almost none of it.

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Explanation

Digital footprints

A digital footprint is everything about you that exists online because of what you do there. It grows in two ways. The **active** footprint is what you deliberately put out: your posts, photos, comments, likes, profile details, the reviews you write. The **passive** footprint is what is collected about you as you simply use the internet: the sites you visit, the searches you make, your approximate location, the device and apps you use, what you pause to watch. You chose none of the passive part, and you see almost none of it - but it exists, and it is often sold, merged, and profiled.

Why does this matter for a teacher more than for most people? Three reasons. First, teachers are searched: by employers, by parents, by pupils. A pupil who finds a teacher's old post does not read it charitably. Second, teachers model behaviour: a class that watches its teacher share a forwarded rumour without checking learns exactly that habit. Third, in Pakistan's context, where the same phone carries your professional life, your family groups and your banking, a footprint is not a separate identity - it is your identity, searchable.

Six traces: active or passive?

Trace	Active or passive	Who can see it
a photo you post	active	anyone, depending on privacy settings
a comment you write	active	the platform and its readers
your profile details	active	the platform and often advertisers
your search history	passive	the search engine and sites you visit
your location data	passive	apps and their partners
contacts uploaded by an app	passive	the app and whoever it shares with

Managing the footprint is not hiding; it is choosing. The working audit has three questions. **What is already there?** Search your own name in more than one search engine, look at the images tab, and check what your public profile shows to a stranger. **What keeps growing?** Your settings: review who can see future posts, turn off location sharing for apps that do not need it, and think before each post - the internet forgets nothing reliably. **What do you put out deliberately?** This is the part you control completely, and for a trainee teacher it is worth curating: the poetry blog helped the candidate above far more than the old comment hurt her, and both were equally hers.

One more habit belongs here because it is about other people's footprints, not yours: do not post photographs of pupils or share their details without the school's permission. Children cannot consent to a footprint, and in Unit 6's terms, they will carry it longer than you will carry yours.

Activity: The three-question audit

Work in pairs. About 15 minutes.

1. Each partner writes (privately, on paper, not to share) the answers to the three audit questions for themselves: what is already there, what keeps growing, what I put out deliberately.
2. Together, without reading each other's notes, discuss: which of the six traces in the second figure would a future employer most likely see? Rank the top three.
3. Agree on one setting each of you will change tonight (privacy, location, or notifications) and write it down.
4. Swap lists of what counts as a "good deliberate trace" for a teacher - what would you want a panel to find?

Check your understanding

1. Define a digital footprint in one sentence. (*Remember*)
2. Explain the difference between the active and passive footprint, with one example of each. (*Understand*)

3. A friend argues: "I have nothing to hide, so I do not care about my footprint." Give two reasons why a teacher specifically should care anyway.
(Apply)
4. Name two traces you can reduce tonight and the setting that controls each.
(Apply)

Summary

A digital footprint is the trail you leave online: the active part you publish (posts, comments, profiles) and the passive part collected about you (searches, location, app activity). Teachers are searched more than most people, model online behaviour for pupils, and live professional and personal lives on one phone - so the footprint is worth auditing on three questions: what is already there, what keeps growing, what I put out deliberately. And pupils' data is never yours to publish.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define a digital footprint and distinguish active from passive traces.
- ☐ I can run the three-question audit on myself.
- ☐ I can explain why a teacher's footprint matters more than most people's.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask two or three colleagues (or your cooperating teacher) whether anyone has ever searched them online, and what they found. Note the answers anonymously. Bring back one sentence: does the school have any habit or rule about posting pupil photographs?

Summative task

Write a one-page "footprint audit" for yourself as a future teacher: what a search of your name currently shows (or would show), which traces help and which harm your professional image, and three concrete actions you will take - one to clean, one to curate, one to prevent.

Marking guide (10 marks):

- The audit describes actual trace types, not vague worries: 3 marks.
- Help and harm judged with reasons tied to the teaching profession (Analyse): 4 marks.
- Three actions are concrete and each names the setting or habit involved: 2 marks.
- Clear, honest, one page: 1 mark.

Further reading

- National Cybersecurity Alliance. *Stay Safe Online: managing your digital footprint*. <https://staysafeonline.org/>
- Bourgeois, D. T., Smith, J. L., Wang, S., & Mortati, J. (2019). *Information Systems for Business and Beyond* (2nd ed.), chapter 6. Open Textbook Library. <https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/information-systems-for-business-and-beyond>
- Laudon, K. C., & Laudon, J. P. *Management Information Systems*. Pearson. (Course guide reading; print monograph, cited at bibliographic level.)

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